

METHODOLOGY

With as many as 592 respondents ranging from MBA aspirants to top recruiters and functional heads, the fifth Best B-school BT-AC-Nielsen-ORG-MARG survey has expanded its reach from last year. More than 811 interviews were conducted in 12 cities. The survey was done in two phases—30 schools were shortlisted in the first phase, out of which the final list was then compiled. Respondents were asked to give their wishlist on the basis of different parameters like reputation, placements, infrastructure, faculty, teaching methodology, admission eligibility and specialist units. A brand equity index (BEI) was arrived at by assessing consumer loyalty as well as the price premium. Finally, BEI for different respondents was combined to arrive at the final rank list.

OUTCOME: Graduates at Management Development Institute, Gurgaon.



last year—of the total pie of determinants of brand equity of a school. The institute's reputation has notched up an additional 2 per cent in the same factor table. Giving too much importance to this factor, however, could be tricky, especially with the schools that do little to maintain their reputation.

The survey also highlighted the change in the way people look at B-schools other than the hallowed IIMs. Despite occupying top positions, there has been a substantial dip in the brand equity ratings of the top five institutes—IIM-A, B, and C, Symbiosis Pune and IIM-L. This does not imply that the holy trinity is on its way out, but that they have not been able to spread their wings as other institutes, which have gained tremendous ground. Welingkar has jumped to the fifth position from the tenth. In its feedback from functional heads, the institute notched up 25 places to acquire the third rank, outwitting the IIMs. Similarly, Narsee Monjee in Mumbai has been able to regain its 10th rank, after slipping down to 17 in 2006, buoyed by the positive feedback from executives and HR heads.

Does this mean that we have finally entered an age of the discerning MBA aspirant and an even more demanding MBA employer? Not yet, say experts. For one, the IIMs still figure quite high on the aspirational ladder, almost towering over the other schools. Even among the IIMs, IIM-Ahmedabad appears to be invincible, while IIM-Bangalore ranks second.

However, there is still hope for those who were once considered oh-so-fallible. For one, there are a number of new entrants in the "distinct" brands category. The biggest gainers have been IIT-Delhi and ICFAI, Mumbai, which have jumped to number 14 and 19, respectively. The other new ones on the block are T.A. Pai in Manipal, Sydenham in Mumbai and South Indian Educational Society (SIES) in Navi Mumbai, which got positive feedback from functional heads and executives. SIES Director A.K. Gupta explains that the school places great importance on research as a "differen-